

Working in partnership

Why do community groups want to partner with the university?

When you contact a community or organisation, it is vital to find out more about their motivations and expectations for partnering with you, as well as any previous experiences working with the university.

Unless you are planning on co-creating the module with partners, you should be able to establish all this in a few initial meetings.

In these meetings, you can outline key details about the module, timelines, how it will be assessed, and what the community group can expect. At this point, it is vital to manage expectations and be flexible where you can and respond to your partner's needs.



Six considerations for developing partnerships



Establish Contact

When you contact a community or organisation, it is vital to find out more about their motivations and expectations for partnering with you, as well as any previous experiences working with the university.

Unless you are planning on co-creating the module with partners, you should be able to establish all this in a few initial meetings.

In these meetings, you can outline key details about the module, timelines, how it will be assessed, and what the community group can expect. At this point, it is vital to manage expectations and be flexible where you can and respond to your partner's needs.

02

Create Alignment

Creating alignment with partners around your teaching and/or research priorities is crucial to generating partnerships that generate benefits for both students, the university and the communities that are taking part. To do this, you must first understand what the goals your partner hopes to gain from the relationship and how well these goals align with the learning priorities for the programme.

Key questions you can ask your partner to help surface areas for alignment include:

- What are the key challenges they face?
- What do they hope to gain from working with you/the University?
- Have they had any previous experience?
- What ideas do they have for projects your students can do?
- What existing data do they already have or are aware of?
- What would the outcome be? What timeline do they need for this to work
- How much time can they invest in supporting students? In working with you?
- Are there any ethical issues you need to be aware of? (e.g. students working with vulnerable groups).

03

Look beyond CEL for what you can offer

Often, a partner will be interested in CEL as part of a broader set of benefits they can gain from working with you. Perhaps they want access to your research, other departments, or facilities, like rooms they can use for project meetings. They may approach you with a request that cannot be met within your programme, for example, due to content or timings. Make sure you have people working with you at the University who can help facilitate those connections. Sometimes, you will signpost requests or facilitate introductions to other areas of the university, such as the volunteering team.



04

Build mutual benefits

Building trust and relationships with partners is vital, and to do so, each person must stay committed to the relationship and ensure it is not extractive. Understanding the motives and needs of your community partner is an important first step in building mutually beneficial relationships. However, true equity in partnership work requires both understanding and commitment.

Take a moment to reflect on your module and consider the extent to which you agree with or disagree with the following position statements, and what steps you're prepared to take to ensure your actions align with your position:

- Communities have a right to contribute, shape and inform the knowledge produced about them?
- The relationships you're developing will outlast the project and are essential in their own right?
- We will try to involve all partners in deciding what form a CEL project takes?
- Knowledge originates from the University, and Communities provide a 'living lab' to test and develop these ideas?
- This module is accountable to people beyond those directly involved?
- We want to create outputs that are useful and valuable to people in the project?

05

Position expertise

Community Engaged Learning can offer the opportunity to question the idea that scientific knowledge is a higher form of knowledge than others. It recognises that knowing is not limited to formal theories or detached observation, but also emerges through practice, experience, relationships, and place.

Rather than treating objectivity as the gold standard, CEL can emphasise how knowledge is shaped by context, identity, and lived experience. This approach also challenges the idea that communities are simply recipients of academic insight instead, they are understood as holders of knowledge in their own right. Within this model, students are not positioned as passive learners or experts-in-training, but as active participants who learn with rather than about communities, engaging in a mutual process of discovery and transformation.



06

Communicate

Clear communication is an essential part of any CEL partnership. Being prepared, being responsive, and being flexible when things do not go as planned can all go a long way to ensure a good experience for all involved. One way to structure this is to create a checklist or a summary brief which includes everything you need to discuss or stay in contact about.

This might include:

- A project summary
- The work students will do
- The support that the University and the partner will provide
- How the relationship will be managed
- Any outputs or IP that will be produced
- Additional requests or interests from the partner
- A risk assessment
- A timeline

Make sure this is a live brief, and you share it with partners and students for feedback, utilising it as a cornerstone for your work together.

Further Reading

This guide developed by UCL is an excellent resource to engaging the London community.

<https://www.ucl.ac.uk/teaching-learning/publications/2019/nov/how-build-partnerships-external-partners-enhance-learning>

Activity

Take a moment to reflect on where you stand along the following spectrums related to power, accountability, connection and trust.

